# Sustainable livelihoods: Connecting the rural and urban poor in Uganda

Overcrowded housing in Kivulu slum (UYSA, 2016)


**Executive Summary:**

- This research addresses **Sustainable Development Goal** (**SDG**) 11 which aims to 'Make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable' (UN, 2015), in the context of Uganda.
- Rural-urban migration is a strategy used by the poor to split livelihoods between rural and urban areas.
- This research finds that second-generation migrants still use rural-urban ties to maintain livelihoods through gaining access to assets, including financial, human, natural, physical and social.
- Therefore, rural-urban connections need to be considered when creating effective **pro-poor policy**
- The poor are **active citizens** that should be included in policy making processes.


## Pro-poor policy:

Current conceptualisations of poverty understand it to be a 'condition of insecurity rather than only a lack of wealth' (Meikle et al. 2001, p.1). Therefore**, pro-poor policies** need to reduce the insecurities and vulnerabilities of the poor, so they can improve their situations.

## Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs):

Goal 11 of the SDGs is:

**'Make cities and human settlements inclusive, safe, resilient and sustainable'**

(UN, 2015)

This research specifically focusses on sub-section A of Goal 11:

*'Support positive economic, social and environmental links between urban, per-urban and rural areas by strengthening national and regional development planning'* (Ibid).

## Ugandan context:

Migration is used as a livelihood strategy by the poor to create a diversified income (Barrett et al., 2012). In 2015, Uganda's urban population growth was 5.4% annually, but a majority of the population still live in rural areas (World Bank, 2016a: World Bank, 2016b).

## Research context:

First generation rural-urban migrants have been shown to have strong rural-urban connections, including sharing assets (financial, human, natural, physical and social) between rural and urban areas to maintain or improve their livelihoods (Tacoli and Mabala, 2010).

The number of second generation rural-urban migrants living in urban areas is high (Crush, 2013), but currently there is little understanding as to how they use their rural-urban connections to encourage strong livelihoods.

Current policy in Africa does not engage with these multi-spatial households (Andersson Djurfeldt, 2012) even though they are crucial for many of the urban and rural poor.

**Method:** Qualitative semi-structured interviews were carried out with 9 second generation rural-urban migrants and 5 stakeholders. Interviews took place in Katanga, Kivulu and Namuwongo, three poor communities in Kampala, Uganda.

**Empirical evidence:**

Financial assets:

- Rural areas relied on money from urban contacts. Rural dwellers were forced to sell belongings when they could not get money from their urban contact.
- Nearly all second generation rural-urban migrants give money to rural areas.
- Financial exchange from rural to urban dwellers also occurred in times of need.

Human assets:

- Rural dwellers use urban contacts to access healthcare and medication on a short and long term basis.

Natural assets:

- Some urban dwellers owned/inherited land in rural areas. Other urban dwellers only had access to land when they visited rural areas but did not own the land themselves.
- Rural dwellers supplied urban contacts with food produce to sell and or for consumption.

Physical assets:

- Expensive, rented housing common in poor urban areas. Often high levels of over-crowding in urban areas.
- Some second generation rural-urban migrants owned houses in rural areas.
- Some migrants said they would consider moving/ had moved to rural areas if rent got more difficult to pay

Social assets:

- Rural-urban linkages used to access resources, job opportunities and support networks in urban areas for rural dwellers.
- Urban dwellers used rural-urban linkages to access childcare, food, resources and support networks in rural areas.

**Key findings:**

- **Second generation rural-urban migrants still had strong connections with their rural homelands.**
- **Rural-urban connection helps second generation rural-urban migrants to access assets including: financial, human, natural, physical and social.**
- **This helps them to reduce their vulnerability and improve positive livelihood outcomes.**
- **Urban and rural poor are therefore active citizens that use their linkages to maintain or improve their livelihoods during difficult times.**

## Policy recommendations:

- Urban and rural local governments need to coordinate their policies, incorporating **rural-urban connections**.
- To create effective **pro-poor policy** rural and urban areas need to be understood as linked.
- The poor need to be understood as **active citizens** and should therefore participate in the policy making process – also improves sustainability.


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